Muhammad Usman Naeem

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Education

Tufts University — Medford, MA, USA
Ph.D., Economics & Public Policy — Expected 2027
Fields: Development; Environmental; Behavioural; Public

Lahore University of Management Sciences — Lahore, Pakistan
M.S., Economics — 2015

National University of Singapore — Singapore
B.A., Economics — 2009

Research Positions

Harvard University, Department of Economics — Cambridge, MA, USA
Visiting Fellow — Jan–Jun 2026

International Growth Centre — Pakistan
Country Economist — 2015–2021

References

Steve Cicala	**Kyle Emerick**	**Michael Greenstone**	**Frank Schilbach**
steve.cicala@tufts.edu	kyle.emerick@tufts.edu	mgreenst@uchicago.edu	fschilb@mit.edu

Job Market Paper

"The Idle Margin: Why Everyday Conservation Goes Undone"

Abstract. Vehicle transport is a major source of air pollution, yet little is known about why drivers persist in behaviours that impose private costs and generate avoidable emissions. I study vehicle idling—leaving the engine running while stopped—as a repeated conservation decision with private and social benefits. With a telematics firm in Pakistan, I conduct a randomised field experiment with 6,621 private vehicles using 10-second GPS data. An additive treatment design varies private information, social information, payments, and a real-time reminder. Baseline beliefs reveal widespread misperceptions about engine warm-up and when shutting off begins to save fuel or reduce environmental harm. Private information reduces idling from stops longer than 30 seconds by 1.8 minutes per observed vehicle-day, or 9% of the control mean, with effects persisting after treatment ends. Over eight weeks, estimated benefits are 3.7 times programme costs. Social information and payments add little. By contrast, activating the reminder increases idling by 1.0 minute relative to an otherwise identical no-reminder arm, with 81% of the increase arising beyond two minutes. Mechanism evidence indicates that drivers reduce preventive self-monitoring when they expect to rely on the device and then delay corrective action after being reminded. The results identify private misperceptions as an important constraint on repeated conservation and show that externally supplied attention can crowd out rather than reinforce self-monitoring.

Working Papers

"Subsidies and Debt under Nonlinear Electricity Pricing"
with Robin Burgess, Tim Dobermann, Michael Greenstone, and Faraz Hayat

"Preaching Against Power Theft"
with Robin Burgess, Tim Dobermann, Michael Greenstone, and Faraz Hayat

"Hardening the Grid: Technology versus Enforcement"
with Robin Burgess, Tim Dobermann, Michael Greenstone, and Faraz Hayat

Selected Work in Progress

"Small Farms, Coordination, and Air Pollution"
with Steve Cicala and Kyle Emerick

"Making Pollution Visible: Emissions Disclosure"
with Michael Greenstone

Research Grants

Total funding as PI/Co-PI: over $1.1 million.

£57,463 (IGC); $13,972 (Weiss)	The Idle Margin: Why Everyday Conservation Goes Undone
£277,762 (IGC)	Subsidies and Debt under Nonlinear Electricity Pricing
$167,904 (Weiss; K-CAI); £64,097 (IGC)	Preaching Against Power Theft
£124,677 (IGC); $24,874 (Weiss)	Hardening the Grid: Technology versus Enforcement
£31,172 (IGC)	Small Farms, Coordination, and Air Pollution
£66,272 (IGC)	Making Pollution Visible: Emissions Disclosure
$109,938 (ATAI; DERF); £24,919 (IGC)	Technology Subsidies and Crop Residue Burning

Presentations (* forthcoming)

2027	Econometric Society CSW Asia Meeting*
2026	Harvard, Cities & Development Conference*; LSE*; LUMS*; IGC–World Bank ieConnect Roundtable*; Harvard, Development Advising Group; Tufts, NFEPP Workshop*
2025	Stanford, Behavioral Public Economics Boot Camp; Tufts, NFEPP Workshop
2024	Berkeley, Environmental & Energy Economics Summer School; Tufts, NFEPP Workshop
2023	MIT, Behavioral Economics; Tufts, NFEPP Workshop

Teaching

Tufts University — Medford, MA, USA

- Teaching Assistant, Advanced Empirical Methods for Doctoral Students — 2026–2027
- Teaching Assistant, Intermediate Macroeconomic Theory (undergraduate) — 2025–2026
- Teaching Assistant, Behavioral Economics (graduate) — 2023–2026